

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
WASHINGTON, D.C. 20250

DEPARTMENTAL REGULATION	NUMBER: DR 4620-002
SUBJECT: Common Identification Standard for U.S. Department of Agriculture	DATE: April 28, 2026
OPI: Office of Safety, Security, and Protection	EXPIRATION DATE: April 28, 2031

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1. PURPOSE

This Departmental Regulation (DR) prescribes the credentialing standards, policies, roles, and responsibilities for the implementation of Homeland Security Presidential Directive [\(HSPD\) 12](#), *Policy for a Common Identification Standard for Federal Employees and Contractors*, as well as the issuance of alternative identity credentials for short-term, HSPD-12 exempt, or HSPD-12 ineligible populations requiring access to federally controlled facilities and/or federally controlled information systems.

2. SCOPE

This DR applies to all Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices.

3. SPECIAL INSTRUCTIONS/CANCELLATIONS

- This regulation supersedes DR 4620-002, Common Identification Standard for U.S. Department of Agriculture, dated June 24, 2021.

- 1
- 2 b. No provision in this DR shall have the effect of nullifying or limiting protections for
- 3 equal employment opportunity as provided in Title VII of the Civil Rights Act, Equal
- 4 Employment Opportunities, [42 U.S.C. § 2000e](#), et seq., and [Executive Order \(E.O.\)](#)
- 5 [11478](#), Equal Employment Opportunity in the Federal Government and [E.O. 13087](#).
- 6 USDA prohibits discrimination in all its programs and activities on the basis of race,
- 7 color, sex, national origin, religion, age, disability, genetic information, marital status,
- 8 parental status, political affiliation, receipt of public assistance, pregnancy, childbirth, or
- 9 related medical conditions, or any other non-merit based factor. Persons with
- 10 disabilities who require alternative means for communication of program information
- 11 (e.g., Braille, large print, audiotope) should contact USDA's TARGET [Technology and
- 12 Accessible Resources Give Employment Today] Center at (202) 720-2600 (voice and
- 13 Telecommunications Device for the Deaf (TDD)). To file a complaint of discrimination,
- 14 write to USDA, Assistant Secretary for Civil Rights, Office of Civil Rights, Center for
- 15 Civil Rights Enforcement, 1400 Independence Avenue, S.W., Mail Stop 9440,
- 16 Washington, DC 20250-9410 or call 1-800-795-3272 (voice) or (202) 720-6382 (TDD).
- 17 USDA is an equal opportunity provider and employer.
- 18
- 19 c. Outside of the USDA HSPD-12 compliant Personal Identity Verification (PIV) card and
- 20 the alternative credentials referenced in Departmental Manual [\(DM\) 4620-002](#), *Common*
- 21 *Identification Standard for U.S. Department of Agriculture Employees and Contractors*,
- 22 the only authorized badges and credentials issued by USDA will be for law
- 23 enforcement; investigations; food inspection; Farm Production and Conservation
- 24 (FPAC) Loss Adjusters; the Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service (APHIS) Plant,
- 25 Protection and Quarantine program; animal care; physical security use, and alternate
- 26 logical access credentials issued by the Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO).
- 27 This authority will remain in the control of Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices
- 28 such as the Office of the Inspector General, the Forest Service, the Food Safety and
- 29 Inspection Service, FPAC, APHIS, OCIO, and the Office of Safety, Security, and
- 30 Protection (OSSP).
- 31
- 32 d. This policy conforms with Federal Information Security Modernization Act of 2014
- 33 [\(FISMA\)](#), 44 U.S.C. § 3551, et seq. and National Institute of Standards and Technology
- 34 (NIST) Federal Information Processing Standards Publication [\(FIPS PUB\) 201-3](#),
- 35 Personal Identity Verification (PIV) of Federal Employees and Contractors guidelines.
- 36

37 4. BACKGROUND

38

- 39 a. HSPD-12 establishes the general requirements for a common Federal identification
- 40 system. The President has mandated that all Federal departments provide a process for
- 41 identity proofing and credentialing employees and contractors to increase security and
- 42 provide greater interoperability between departments and Federal facilities.
- 43 b. For further information on HSPD-12 and its related requirements and standards, please
- 44 see sources in Appendix C.
- 45

46 5. POLICY

1
2 This policy is established to enhance security, increase Government efficiency, reduce
3 identity fraud, and protect personal privacy by establishing a mandatory, USDA-wide
4 standard for secure and reliable forms of identification to its employees and contractors.
5

- 6 a. Departmental Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices must comply with HSPD-12 for
7 all applicable USDA federal employees and non-Federal employees. Detailed
8 procedures are described in DM 4620-002.
9
- 10 b. The issuance of the HSPD-12 compliant PIV credential, referred to now as the USDA
11 LincPass is mandatory and applies to:
12 (1) All federal employees, as defined in [5 United States Code \(U.S.C.\) §2105](#),
13 “Employee,” within a department or agency whose employment is likely to
14 continue for at least six (6) continuous months and requires physical and/or logical
15 access to federally controlled facilities and/or information systems.
16 (2) All other categories of persons, referred to now as non-Federal employees,
17 performing work for or on behalf of the USDA, such as contractors, grantees,
18 interns, volunteers, affiliates, licensees, certificate holders, fellows, and guest
19 researchers whose engagement is likely to continue for at least six (6) continuous
20 months and requires physical and/or logical access to federally controlled facilities
21 and/or information systems.
22
- 23 c. Federal employees and non-Federal employees whose term is less than six (6)
24 continuous months are considered short-term and are eligible for alternative credentials
25 based on the Mission Area, agency, or staff office risk-based decision and minimum
26 vetting standards outlined in DM4620-002.
27
- 28 d. Intermittent employees with affiliation that extends beyond six continuous months are
29 not considered “short-term.” Similarly, seasonal employees, i.e., employees on
30 permanent appointments who work a seasonal schedule of six months or more on a
31 recurring basis are not considered “short-term”.
32
- 33 e. Non-U.S. nationals who cannot meet the investigative standards for PIV may be eligible
34 for alternative identity credentials based on Mission Area, agency, or staff office risk-
35 based decision and the Office of Personnel Management (OPM) Credentialing Executive
36 Agent (CredEA) investigative standards for non-U.S. nationals.
37
- 38 f. Alternative credentials can provide logical and/or physical access but do not meet the
39 requirements of HSPD-12 and are visually and electronically distinguishable from the
40 LincPass credential. Alternative credential and risk-based decision guidance is found in
41 the [DM-4620-002](#).
42
- 43 g. Federal employees as defined by 5 U.S.C § 2105, and non-Federal employees with
44 USDA will be required to follow procedures in FIPS 201-3, the NIST Special
45 Publication (SP) series related to HSPD-12, and DM 4620-002 for the issuance of a
46 LincPass credential.

1
2 Retired USDA employees must be issued Visitor badges when visiting USDA facilities.
3 Previously issued retirement badges must be revoked, collected from the former
4 employees, and destroyed.
5

6 6. ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES 7

8 a. The Director of OSSP will: 9

- 10 (1) Develop, in consultation with the USDA Office of Homeland Security (OHS) and
11 the OCIO, policies, standards, and procedures for implementing and administering
12 the HSPD-12 program throughout the Department;
13
- 14 (2) Work with Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices to maintain policies and
15 procedures to support the identity proofing, registration, and credentialing of
16 employees;
17
- 18 (3) Maintain an enterprise Physical Access Control System (ePACS) environment to
19 support Mission Area, agency, and staff office physical access control systems;
20
- 21 (4) Oversee and assist with migrating all physical access control systems into HSPD-12
22 compliance;
23
- 24 (5) Support role holder training module development;
25
- 26 (6) Support Mission Areas, agencies, and staff offices with the roles and
27 responsibilities for managing non-Federal employees in accordance with [DM 4620-](#)
28 [002](#); and
29
- 30 (7) Set the standards for the hosting of credentialing stations within USDA that follow
31 or exceed USAccess requirements.
32
- 33 (8) Develop oversight and audit processes to assess Mission Area, Agency, and Staff
34 Office compliance with credentialing standards.
35

36 b. The USDA Chief Information Officer (CIO) will: 37

- 38 (1) Assist OSSP with maintaining connectivity to the various enterprise systems that
39 support HSPD-12 requirements;
40
- 41 (2) Work with the Privacy Office to ensure personal information collected for
42 employee and contractor identification purposes is handled consistent with the
43 Privacy Act of 1974, [5 U.S.C. § 552a](#) and all FISMA requirements (see 44 U.S.C. §
44 3551, et seq.);
45

- 1 (3) Issue and coordinate a derived PIV credential in accordance with [NIST Special](#)
2 [Publication 800-157](#), Guidelines for Derived Personal Identity Verification (PIV)
3 Credentials; and
4
- 5 (4) Maintain policies and procedures for the issuance of logical access PIV exemptions
6 and non-PIV alternative multi-factor authentication credentials.
7
- 8 c. The Director of the Office of Human Resources Management (OHRM) will:
9
- 10 (1) Develop, maintain, and disseminate on-boarding policies and procedures for
11 Mission Area, agency, and staff office Human Resources staff that support the
12 timely issuance of a credential; and
13
- 14 (2) Develop, maintain, and disseminate off-boarding policies and procedures that
15 include the collection of identification credentials for Mission Area, agency, and
16 staff office Human Resources staff.
17
- 18 d. The Director of the Office of Contracting and Procurement (OCP) will:
19
- 20 (1) Provide HSPD-12 procurement and contracting guidance to the acquisition
21 workforce through OCP PGI 404.1301 and 411.107 of the USDA Contracting Desk
22 Book;
23
- 24 (2) Prepare guidance and Blanket Purchase Agreements (BPA) to ensure that HSPD-12
25 compliant equipment is purchased; and
26
- 27 (3) Issue contractor on-boarding and off-boarding procedures for the Contracting
28 Officer Representative to include the collection of the USDA issued credentials on
29 contractor departure.
30
- 31 e. The Chief Financial Officer (CFO) will:
32
- 33 (1) Maintain and update EmpowHR/Person Model in a timely manner; and
34
- 35 (2) Provide financial oversight and management of HSPD-12 funding.
36
- 37 f. The Director of the Office of Homeland Security (OHS) will:
38
- 39 (1) Develop and maintain the policies and procedures required for administering the
40 Department's Personnel Security program, to include personnel vetting for which
41 PIV and alternate credential eligibility, adjudication, and reciprocity determinations
42 are based in accordance with the Federal Investigative Standards; and
43
- 44 (2) Develop and maintain policies and procedures for the reporting of information
45 requiring the suspension or termination of a PIV credential to appropriate HSPD-12

1 role holders for timely action.

2
3 g. Mission Area, agency, and staff office Chief Executive Officers (CXO) and Chief
4 Operating Officers (COO) will:

- 5
6 (1) Comply with all relevant HSPD-12 requirements such as NIST FIPS PUB 201-3,
7 NIST SPs, DR 3505-003, DR 3640-001, and DM 4620-002;
8
9 (2) Utilize the USDA credential matrix to determine the necessary credential type
10 based on citizenship, level of access, personnel security vetting, and employment
11 duration required. To access the credential matrix, see DM 4620-002;
12
13 (3) Issue AltLinc (PIV-I) to applicable categories of short-term individuals based on the
14 agency risk-based decision that complies with [OMB, Memorandum M-05-24](#).
15
16 (4) Develop policies and procedures for the issuance of any alternative credentials other
17 than the PIV-I within their Mission Area, agency or staff office.
18
19 (5) Remove from Federal service any employee denied a USDA LincPass (PIV) or
20 AltLinc (PIV-I). The appeal process for a removal from Federal service is already
21 established in law and regulation see [5 U.S.C. § 7513\(d\)](#), Cause and Procedure; [5](#)
22 [Code of Federal Regulations \(CFR\) § 752.405](#), *Appeal and Grievance Rights*;
23
24 (6) Comply with Departmental policies and procedures to support registration, identity
25 proofing, and issuance of approved USDA issued credentials;
26
27 (7) Ensure Mission Area, agency, and staff office applicants (employee and non-
28 employee) complete the sponsorship, enrollment, and adjudication process for their
29 USDA LincPass (PIV) or AltLinc (PIV-I) prior to onboarding;
30
31 (8) Comply with USDA physical and logical access control policies and procedures;
32
33 (9) In consultation with Mission Area, staff office, or agency contracting office, ensure
34 HSPD-12 products and services are compliant with FIPS PUB 201-3 and Office of
35 Management and Budget (OMB) guidance;
36
37 (10) Assign an HSPD-12 Agency Lead and alternate to the HSPD-12 Program Office
38 that is responsible for program implementation within the Mission Area, agency, or
39 staff office;
40
41 (11) Ensure HSPD-12 roles such as Sponsor, Security Officer, Adjudicator, Role
42 Administrator, Registrar, and Activator are assigned in accordance with DM-4620-
43 002 to ensure employees receive their USDA credential in a timely manner.
44
45 (12) Identify all personnel requiring Federal Emergency Response Official (FERO)
46 designation and ensure designations are printed on the LincPass (PIV) by making

1 the required positions, roles, or specific personnel available to the Sponsor role
2 holders.
3

4 (13) Manage Mission Area, agency, or staff office hosted credentialing stations and
5 ensure the placement, staffing, and availability are adequate to service the card
6 holder population.
7

8 (14) Assign an ePACS Agency Segment Administrator (ASA) to the ePACS Program
9 Office that is responsible for program implementation within the Mission Area,
10 agency, or staff office.
11

12 (15) Ensure that ePACS Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) documents are
13 reviewed and signed as appropriate
14

15 (16) Ensure that agency Physical Access Control Systems are compliant with HSPD-12,
16 FICAM, and other applicable standards.
17

18 h. Employees will comply with Departmental policies and procedures related to USDA
19 LincPass (PIV) and alternative credential issuance and maintenance. This includes
20 adhering to deadlines for credential and certificate renewal.
21

22 7. CREDENTIAL UTILIZATION 23

24 a. See DR 3505-003, Access Control for Information, and Information Systems (logical
25 access requirements), DR 3640-001, Identity, Credential, and Access Management
26 [ICAM], and DM 4620-002 for further clarification on logical access requirements.
27

28 b. See DM 4620-002, Section 11a, Physical Access Control Systems (PACS) for physical
29 access requirements.
30

31 8. INQUIRIES 32

33 Questions regarding this DR should be directed to OSSP at 202-401-6777 or
34 securityservicehelp@usda.gov.
35
36

37 -END-

APPENDIX A

ACRONYMS AND ABBREVIATIONS

1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6	APHIS	Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service
7	BPA	Blanket Purchase Agreement
8	CFO	Chief Financial Officer
9	CFR	Code of Federal Regulations
10	CIO	Chief Information Officer
11	COO	Chief Operating Officer
12	CredEA	Credentialing Executive Agent
13	CXO	Chief Executive Officer
14	DM	Departmental Manual
15	DR	Departmental Regulation
16	ePACS	Enterprise Physical Access Control System
17	E.O.	Executive Order
18	FERO	Federal Emergency Response Official
19	FICAM	Federal Identity Credential and Access Management
20	FIPS PUB	Federal Information Processing Standards Publication
21	FISMA	Federal Information Security Modernization Act
22	HSPD-12	Homeland Security Presidential Directive 12
23	ICAM	Identity, Credential, and Access Management
24	IT	Information Technology
25	LACS	Logical Access Control System
26	NIST	National Institute of Standards and Technology
27	OCIO	Office of the Chief Information Officer
28	OCP	Office of Contracting and Procurement
29	OHRM	Office of Human Resources Management
30	OHS	Office of Homeland Security
31	OMB	Office of Management and Budget
32	OPM	Office of Personnel Management
33	OSSP	Office of Safety, Security, and Protection
34	PACS	Physical Access Control System
35	PIV	Personal Identity Verification
36	PIV-D	Personal Identity Verification Derived
37	PIV-I	Personal Identity Verification Interoperable
38	PMO	Program Management Office
39	SP	Special Publication
40	TARGET	Technology and Accessible Resources Give Employment Today
41	TDD	Telecommunications Device for the Deaf
42	U.S.C.	United States Code
43	USDA	United States Department of Agriculture

APPENDIX B

DEFINITIONS

Access Control. The process of granting or denying requests to access physical facilities or areas, or to logical systems (e.g., computer networks or software applications). See also “logical access control system” and “physical access control system.”

Access (Routine). Entry into and use of a facility and/or information system on a regular basis without an escort and/or continuous monitoring by a USDA official. The Mission Area, agency, and staff office determination should be based upon the support to successfully complete USDA’s mission functions. Routine access requires a mandatory PIV or PIV-I credential to be issued.

Access (Unaccompanied). Entry into and use of a facility and/or information system without an escort and/or continuous monitoring by a USDA official. The Mission Area, agency, and staff office’s determination for unaccompanied access should be based upon the support to successfully complete USDA’s mission functions. Unaccompanied access requires a mandatory LincPass to be issued.

AltLinc (PIV-I). USDA has named their common identity PIV-I card the AltLinc, as it is designed to link a person’s identity to an identification card and the card to a person’s ability to access Federal buildings and computer systems. This card will be used to service short-term personnel (less than 6 months) and personnel who fail to meet the HSPD-12 minimum investigative requirements. The spelling of the AltLinc PIV-I card is derived from the word alternative as it is meant to serve as an alternative to the LincPass.

Contractor. An individual under contract to USDA (for the purpose of HSPD-12 implementation).

Credential. An identity card (“smart card”), also known as LincPass or AltLinc, that contains stored identity credentials. The card is issued to an individual and the claimed identity of the cardholder can be verified against stored credentials by another person or by an automated process. Other approved forms of a credential may be issued when applicable.

Employee. Defined in 5 U.S.C. § 2105, “Employee,” within a department or Mission Area, agency, and staff office. “Employee” means a person, other than the President and Vice President, employed by, detailed or assigned to, USDA, including members of the Armed Forces; an expert or consultant to USDA; an industrial or commercial contractor, licensee, certificate holder, or grantee of USDA, including all subcontractors; or any other category of person who acts on behalf of an Mission Area, agency, and staff office as determined by the Mission Area, agency, and staff office head.

Federal Facility. The term “Federal facility” means any building, structure, or fixture or part thereof which is owned by the United States or any Federal agency or which is held by the

1 United States or any Federal agency under a lease-acquisition agreement under which the
2 United States or a Federal agency will receive fee simple title under the terms of such
3 agreement without further negotiation. Such term also applies to facilities related to programs
4 administered by Federal agencies.
5

6 Federal Emergency Response Official (FERO). A federal agency employee or contractor
7 who performs functions related to the National Response Framework (NRF), National
8 Infrastructure Protection Plan (NIPP), or National Continuity Policy Implementation Plan
9 (NCP/IP). The NCP/IP includes Continuity of Operations and Continuity of Government
10 members. Public Law 110-53 applies to incident management personnel, emergency
11 response providers, other personnel, and resources supporting the response to a natural
12 disaster, act of terrorism, or other emergencies
13

14 Logical Access Control System (LACS). Protection mechanisms that limit a user's access to
15 information and restrict their forms of access on the system to only what is appropriate for
16 them. LACS may be built into an operating system, application, or an added system.
17

18 Non-Federal Employee. A person with a relationship with the USDA other than employment,
19 such as through a contract, grant, agreement, or memorandum of understanding, doing work
20 for or on behalf of the USDA, such as a contractor, affiliate, fellow, intern, or volunteer.
21

22 Physical Access Control System (PACS). Protection mechanisms that limit users' access to
23 physical facilities or areas to only what is appropriate for them. These systems typically
24 involve a combination of hardware and software (e.g., a card reader), and may involve
25 human control (e.g., a security guard)
26

27 USDA LincPass (PIV). USDA has named their common identity card the LincPass, as it is
28 designed to link a person's identity to an identification card and the card to a person's ability
29 to access Federal buildings and computer systems. The spelling of LincPass is a tribute to
30 President Abraham Lincoln, who created the Department of Agriculture, also known as the
31 People's Department, in 1862.

1 APPENDIX C

2
3 AUTHORITIES AND REFERENCES

4
5
6 *Appeal and Grievance Rights*, [5 CFR § 752.405](#)

7
8 *Cause and Procedure*, [5 U.S.C. § 7513\(d\)](#)

9
10 [CIO Counsel Personal Identity Verification Interoperability For Issuers Version 2.0.1](#), July
11 27, 2017

12
13 Title VII of the *Civil Rights Act, Equal Employment Opportunities*, [42 U.S.C. § 2000e](#), *et*
14 *seq.*

15
16 *Employee*, [5 U.S.C. § 2105](#)

17
18 [Executive Order \(E.O.\) 11478](#), *Equal Opportunity Employment in the Federal Government*,
19 August 8, 1969

20
21 *Federal Information Security Modernization Act of 2014* ([FISMA](#)), 44 U.S.C. § 3551, *et seq.*

22
23 Homeland Security Presidential Directive ([HSPD](#)) 12, *Policy for a Common Identification*
24 *Standard for Federal Employees and Contractors*, August 27, 2004

25
26 NIST, [FIPS PUB 201-3](#), *Personal Identity Verification (PIV) of Federal Employees and*
27 *Contractors*, January 2022

28
29 NIST, [SP 800-157](#), *Guidelines for Derived Personal Identity Verification (PIV) Credentials*,
30 December 2014

31
32 OMB, Memorandum [M-05-24](#), *Implementation of Homeland Security Presidential Directive*
33 *(HSPD) 12 – Policy for a Common Identification Standard for Federal Employees and*
34 *Contractors*, August 5, 2005

35
36 OMB, Memorandum [M-19-17](#), *Enabling Mission Delivery through Improved Identity,*
37 *Credential, and Access Management*, May 21, 2019

38
39 *Privacy Act of 1974*, [5 U.S.C. § 552a](#)

40
41 USDA, [DM 4620-002](#), *Common Identification Standard for U.S. Department of Agriculture*
42 *Employees and Contractors*, January 14, 2009

43
44 USDA, [DR 3505-003](#), *Access Control for Information and Information Systems*, July 19,
45 2019

1 USDA, [DR 3640-001](#), *Identity, Credential, and Access Management*, June 8, 2021

2
3 USDA, [DR 4300-003](#), *Equal Opportunity Public Notification Policy*, October 17, 2019

4
5 USDA, OCP, [Procurement Advisory No. 115](#), *Continued Implementation of LincPass at*
6 *USDA*, August 7, 2013